to appear for the DSSC was granted in mid-2021, with fifteen women officers appearing for the entrance exam held in September 2022, out of which six women officers qualified to join DSSC-77, which commenced in April 2023.[10] These anomalies had to be removed to make a level playing field. Once again, there were murmurs among the women officers that this was being done to 'sort them out' and somehow make them ineligible for promotion. A lot of effort had to go in, through the intervention of the Army Commanders, who called and spoke to many women officers in their respective commands, to explain to them that these courses were meant to empower them to hold senior positions in their respective services so that they would not be disadvantaged at a later stage. Hypothetically, while commanding their respective Regiments, suppose an SC-qualified male officer were to get a better CR than a non-SC-qualified woman officer, would that once again amount to discrimination? Slowly but surely, the feeling of dissatisfaction that had permeated the ranks of the women officers dissipated as the women officers once again started having Belief in their senior leadership. The most expressive example of that was the interview given by Lt Col Anila Khatri on the occasion of Women's Day 2022, in which she said, '. . . what gender bias . . . actually there is reverse gender bias . . . [against male officers] . . .'[11] It really made my heart swell with pride when I saw that interview and I felt so fortunate that I have such committed officers serving the Indian Army.

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Covid Pandemic

My entire tenure as Chief was under the shadow of the Covid pandemic. The first reported case in India was from Kerala on 27 January 2020, detected in a female medical student who had